

New target

Avon Lake's Nealon hits jumpers, leads Shoremen past Bay, 55-41

Chris Assenheimer
The Chronicle-Telegram

AVON LAKE — As a starting linebacker for the regional finalist Avon Lake football team, Brian Nealon spent the fall hitting opposing players.

Friday night against Bay, the senior was hitting jump shots.

Dubbed "The Rock" for his burly 6-1, 210-pound frame, Nealon shocked Bay with a career-high 20 points, leading the Shoremen to a 55-41 victory in their final home game of the season.

It was Avon Lake's first win in the last seven games, upping the Shoremen's season record to 5-13 overall and 2-11 in the Southwestern Conference. The Rockets fell to 4-14 overall and 3-9 in the conference, losing its third straight.

"He (Nealon) won the game for them," said Rocket head coach Dick Scott, who was at a loss for words regarding his team's dismal performance. "He made just about everything he shot."

Scott wasn't that far off.

Nealon made 9 of his 13 shot attempts for the game, displaying a perimeter shooting touch that even surprised himself.

"At first I thought it was luck, but once they kept going in, I was saying this isn't luck anymore," he said. "I knew it was the last time I would be on this floor. It was a special feeling."

Bay felt Nealon's sting in both the first and third quarters, where he scored all of his points, including the Shoremen's first seven of the game. After Bay had rallied to take the lead at half-time, 22-21, Nealon opened the second frame with seven consecutive points to put A.L. back in front 28-23.

"He (Nealon) certainly came to play tonight," said Shoremen coach Dick Deasy. "He said he felt like he was going to have a big game. It feels good to get a victory, especially now with the tournament coming up."

Things weren't all roses for Avon Lake, which saw the Rockets knot the count at 33 with a little over two minutes left in the third quarter before taking the lead for good on five straight points from sophomore guard Rick Strauch.

The lead escalated to 10 in the final quarter when senior Matt Lora connected on a 3-pointer to

put the Shoremen in front 45-35 with 4:20 left in the game.

The Rockets, who scored more than half their points behind the 3-point stripe (27), were led by Bobby Miller's and Dan Mussulin's 12 points a piece. Both Bay sharpshooters accounted for six of their team's nine triples.

Nealon got some help in the scoring department from guard Matt Pettys, who had 13 points to go along with his seven assists.

Bay is out of the frying pan and into the fire tonight, traveling to Olmsted Falls to meet the SWC-leading Bulldogs, while the Shoremen also face a stiff test, facing state-ranked Elyria West in Elyria Tuesday night.

A.Lake	G	F	T	Bay	G	F	T
Pettys	5	2	13	Glenn	0	1	17
McLara	5	2	5	Miller	4	1	12
McLara	0	0	0	Mussulin	4	1	12
Burke	2	1	6	Zeln	0	1	1
Nealon	9	3	20	Zetser	2	0	4
King	0	0	0	Kohrley	3	0	9
Schaefer	0	0	0	Alexander	0	0	0
Waltz	0	0	1	Burger	0	0	0
Joch	0	0	1	Murphy	1	0	2
Strauch	2	0	5				
Hille	0	0	2				
Totals	18	13	55	Totals	17	4	41

A.Lake	1	2	3	4	T
Bay	11	11	11	8	41

Three-point goals: Avon Lake, Nealon, Pettys, Matt Lora, Burke, Strauch, Bay, Miller, Mussulin, Kohrley, 3

Amherst rally sinks Fairview, Lutheran West wins MAC-8 title

AMHERST — The Amherst Comets overcame a nine-point halftime deficit to beat Fairview 56-52 Friday night.

Amherst, 13-5 overall and 8-4 in the Southwestern Conference was led by Ross Burke with 18 points, while Bob Rosol had 19 points for Fairview.

The Comets' next game will be at North Olmsted on Tuesday.

Amherst	G	F	T	Fairview	G	F	T
White	4	2	5	Slidmore	3	4	12
Pena	0	3	3	Busanus	3	2	11
Dedrick	1	1	3	Mora	1	3	5
Doucho	3	2	8	Rosol	7	6	19
Slidmore	5	1	11	Phillips	1	0	2
Smith	4	0	8	Nock	1	1	3
Burke	7	3	18				
Totals	27	15	52	Totals	17	15	52

Amherst	1	2	3	4	T
Fairview	13	17	11	11	52

Three-point goals: Amherst 2 (White, Burke), Fairview 3 (Rosol, Slidmore, 2, Busanus), Junior Varsity: Fairview 52-41

North Olmsted.....60
Rocky River.....36

ROCKY RIVER — The Pirates scored seven points in the first half and could not recover, slipping to 9-9, 7-5 in the Southwestern Conference.

North Olmsted took a 19-7 lead at halftime, and stretched it to 41-19 after three quarters.

Joe Smith led all scorers with 13 points for the Eagles (9-8, 6-6).

Chad Standing paced Rocky River with 10.

N.Olmsted	G	F	T	River	G	F	T
Tobert	1	1	4	Pearle	1	3	9
Berardo	1	3	8	Standing	3	4	10
Bleazer	2	2	7	Moran	1	1	3
Gallagher	3	5	11	Kennedy	1	1	3
Lozda	1	1	3	Parquison	2	1	7
Gernick	0	1	1	Nikea	2	2	6
Smith	8	1	13	Lichto	1	0	2
Ryan	1	0	2	Grane	2	0	2
Sutler	1	0	2				
Beck	2	5	8				
Totals	25	19	60	Totals	17	17	58

North Olmsted	1	2	3	4	T
Rocky River	10	9	22	19	60

Three-point goals: North Olmsted 3 (Lozda, Ryan, 2), Standing 3 (Sutler, Beck, 2)

Lutheran West.....73
Independence.....62

INDEPENDENCE — Finally, the MAC-8 is theirs.

The Lutheran West Longhorns, with a win over Independence, won this year's MAC-8 Conference title.

Lutheran West raised their record to 15-3 overall and 11-2 in the conference.

The Longhorns will host Lutheran East on Friday.

L. West	G	F	T	Ind.	G	F	T
Williams	1	0	2	DiGeromo	5	2	18
Koeb	5	2	12	Herzak	1	0	2
Armento	7	6	24	Rutler	2	0	4
Ratnu	2	1	6	Griffin	7	3	18
Ploegstra	1	4	8	Crooks	9	2	20
Fenn	3	11	17	Zimlich	3	2	2
Miller	3	1	7				
Totals	22	25	73	Totals	24	5	62

L. West	1	2	3	4	T
Independence	18	17	12	15	62

Three-point goals: Lutheran West 4 (Argento, 4), Independence 5 (DiGeromo, 4, Griffin) Junior Varsity: Lutheran West 53-47

Strongsville.....65
Midpark.....53

MIDDLEBURG HEIGHTS — Jermaine Sheffield scored a game-high 22 points as Strongsville added to its conference championship with another Pioneer Conference win.

The Mustangs, who had already clinched the title, improved to 14-4, 11-1.

Ted Tsompanos scored 18 and Steve Pisarcik added 16 for the Mustangs (8-10, 5-7).

Strongsville	G	F	T	Midpark	G	F	T
Benson	2	2	4	Pisarcik	8	4	16
Hull	2	2	5	Rayos	0	2	2
Hurley	2	0	6	Hicks	3	0	7
King	5	0	1	Kravac	1	0	2
Walsh	1	0	2	Odovic	4	0	8
Chudy	3	1	7	Tsompianos	8	2	18
Sheffield	7	7	22				
Sai	1	0	2				
Totals	25	10	65	Totals	22	6	63

Strongsville	1	2	3	4	T
Midpark	13	18	13	21	65

Three-point goals: Strongsville, Hurley 2, Sheffield 2, Hull, Midpark 3 (Rayos, 3)

J.V.: Midpark, 52-55, OT.

Open Door.....56
Central Christian.....52

ELYRIA — On a night when Open Door Kevin Delestahtis was awarded for becoming the

third player in Patriots' history to eclipse the 1,000 points mark in last Saturday's Canton Heritage Christian game, Open Door made a historical mark of its own on Friday.

The Patriots (10-10) downed the No. 2 seed in the Division IV Strongsville district tournament Central Christian (15-2).

Open Door will play against Canton Heritage in the first round of the Strongsville tournament Feb. 28.

Open Door	G	F	T	C. Christian	G	F	T
Shaw	1	0	2	Hummel	3	0	4
Turkitt	4	2	12	Subar	2	0	4
Nevea	6	2	14	Yoder	1	2	4
Delestahtis	6	2	14	Kreider	8	2	0
Lauren	5	2	12	Dean	3	2	8
Wells	5	2	12	Wardman	2	0	4
				Punn	1	0	2
				Mosher	1	0	2
				Shuler	1	0	2
Totals	23	5	56	Totals	23	5	52

Open Door	1	2	3	4	T
Central Christian	14	13	12	17	56

Three-point goals: Open Door 2 (Turkitt, 2), Central Christian 2 (Hummel) Junior Varsity: Central Christian 55-40

Lutheran East.....73
First Baptist.....63

ELYRIA — Lutheran East, led by Chris Smith's 21 points, eased by the First Baptist Sabres.

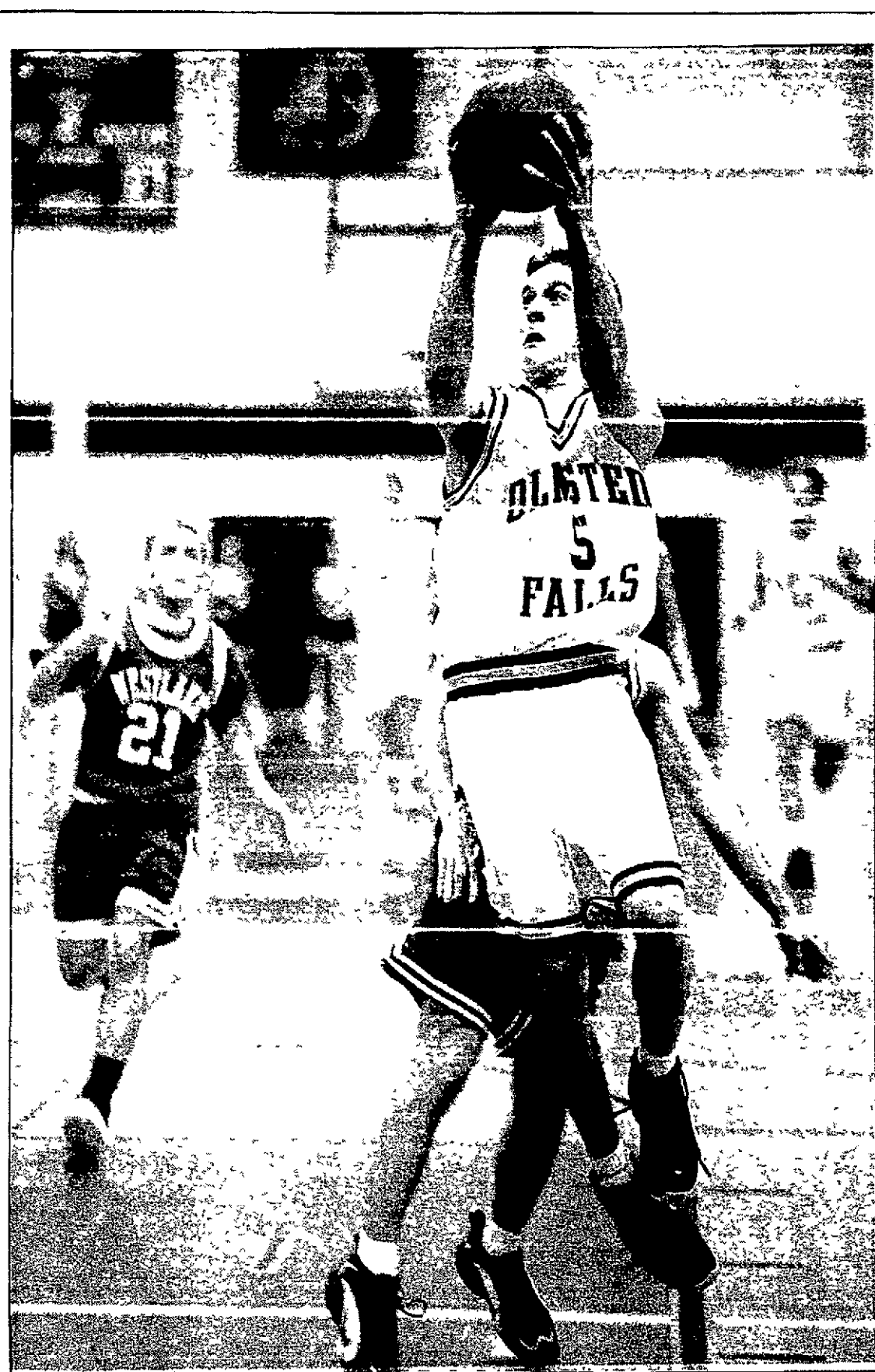
Mike DuBose had 17 points, Marcus Gaines chipped in 16 and Joe Wyly scored 13 for Lutheran East (13-5, 9-1).

The Sabres (8-11, 4-6) were led by Tim Stedman with 23 points.

LE	G	F	T	FB	G	F	T
Thomas	1	0	3	Vance	2	0	6
Gaines	8	0	18	Stedman	9	0	23
Wyly	5	3	13	Vandergrift	3	1	15
DuBose	7	3	17	Davis	2	2	8
Smith	8	4	21	Woodward	1	0	7
Peters	1	1	3	Evans	2	0	4
Totals	35	17	73	Totals	26	4	63

Lutheran East	1	2	3	4	T
First Baptist	10	8	22	33	73

Three-point goals: Lutheran East 2 (Thomas, Smith), First Baptist 7 (Stedman, 5, Vance) Junior Varsity: Lutheran East 51-29



LINDA MURPHY/CHRONICLE

BREAKAWAY: Olmsted Falls' John Storey (5) drives to the basket.

Olmsted Falls blasts Westlake

Steve Byrne
The Chronicle-Telegram

OLMSTED FALLS — How bad was it? Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue started substituting freely with four minutes to go in the first quarter.

This was a no-doubter from the start. The Bulldogs hit six of their first seven field goal attempts and jumped to a 15-2 lead four minutes into their 59-34 victory over Westlake. It was 20-2 after one quarter and 34-8 at the intermission.

The victory made Olmsted Falls 16-2 in all games and undefeated through 12 outings in the Southwestern Conference. Westlake's record is now 7-6 in the conference and 11-8 overall.

"We want to start getting ready for the tournaments, obviously," Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said. "This is probably the first time our players have relaxed and told themselves, 'Let's just play ball.'"

"That's the way they played in the summer. It's good to see again, around tournament time. I hope it stays this way."

The tone was set when Matt Tabar connected on a 3-point

shot five seconds into the game. Nine points in a 2-21 stretch clinched the rout was on.

"They sure came out fired up," Westlake coach Art Daniels said. "That first basket by Tabar got their juices flowing. We missed a few easy shots early and that got us going the other way."

Westlake was 1-of-13 from the field over the first quarter and 2-of-23 for the first half. The Demons committed 16 turnovers in the opening two frames.

The Bulldogs nailed the door shut with 13 unanswered points late in the second period to make the score 33-6.

Tim Schaefer, who entered the game averaging 19.7 points per game, led the way for the Bulldogs with 20 points and an outstanding defensive job.

Westlake's big men, Kevin Houser and Ryan Bibler, were limited to two points each. "Our inside men did well tonight," Donahue said. "Tim, Nick (Neumeister) and Mike (Steppenbacker) all had good games. Our outside shooters (Tim Matus and Tabar) hit just often enough to make Westlake guard them. That opened up the

inside for the others." John Storey came off the bench and paced the Bulldogs with eight rebounds. Steppenbacker was next with seven.

Kyle Blue was Westlake's only bright spot, scoring 15 points. Houser pulled down eight rebounds for the Demons.

Weston Wride's 3-pointer at the horn allowed Westlake to outscore Falls for the second half, 26-25. The Demons committed only seven turnovers after halftime.

"I told our players at half-time to reach inside themselves and to not roll over," Daniels said. "I was pleased with our second half. They didn't just lie down and become totally embarrassed."

Westlake	G	F	T	O Falls	G	F	T
Guilino	0	0	2	Matus	3	2	0
Caproni	1	0	2	Tabar	3	2	10
Westlake	1	0	2	Schaefer	8	4	20
Blue	5	2	15	Neumeister	5	0	10
Houser	1	0	2	Steppenbacker	2	1	5
Yarns	2	0	5	Shorey	1	0	3
Bibler	1	0	2	Moore	0	0	0
Glau	0	0	0	Moran	0	0	0
Armstrong	0	0	0	Higgins	1	0	2
Justice	1	1	3	Polewite	0	1	1
Taylor	0	0	0	Kalamba	1	0	2
Wicks	1	0	3	Schneider	0	0	0
Totals	13	3	33	Totals	23	8	59

Westlake	1	2	3	4	T
Olmsted Falls	2	6	13	13	34

Three-point goals: Blue, 3, Matus, 2, Tabar, 2, Storey, Wride, Yarns

Junior Varsity: Olmsted Falls, 60-58 OT

SPORTS BRIEFS

Skate benefit for Hoffmans

The Elyria Roll Arena on Cleveland St., will donate all its gate proceeds to the family of Brooke and Kyle Hoffman in a special benefit night Thursday, March 7 from 6:30-8:30 p.m.

The two North Ridgeville children, ages 6 and 9, were killed in an automobile accident near Grafton on Jan. 29.

A day before the accident the family had scheduled a special 10th Birthday skating party for Kyle on Feb. 11 at the Roll Arena. When a family member notified the Arena of the party cancellation management decided to schedule the benefit in his honor and for his little sister.

Ticket prices will be \$2, a discount from the regular \$4.75 rate, with all the money, except for \$1.75 skate rental, donated to the Brooke and Kyle Hoff-

man Fund at Elyria Savings and Trust North Ridgeville branch bank on Center Ridge.

Vermilion tickets on sale at school

Tickets for the Feb. 28th Vermilion High boys sectional basketball tournament opener against Fostoria at Sandusky will be presold at the school and Saylorway Middle School Feb. 26-27 until 3 p.m. Prices are \$4 for adults and \$3 for students.

Pool expert at LCCC

Jack White, a pocket pool trick shot artist, will give two clinics at Lorain County Community College Monday, Feb. 26.

The free clinics are open to not only students but the general public from 11 a.m. to 1 p.m. and from 2-4 p.m., in the College Center Mall.

ADMIRAL KING COACH John Rositano was Lorain High's coach last year and lost a key game at Elyria High late in the season on a shot at the buzzer by Brian Todd. Friday night he again lost, this time with the Admirals, on a buzzer shot by Lyle Brown.

"This is beginning to look like a house of horrors for me," Rositano said.

ANDY BENDIK had the red face Friday night. Bendik, Elyria West's scorekeeper, accidentally listed Jakanda Dickerson's number as 15. In his defense, Dickerson did wear jersey 15 to finish Tuesday's game against Firelands after he busted open his lip and dripped some blood on his number 31 and Bendik simply copied the information from Tuesday's game. However, Dickerson wore his old number again on Friday and the error